

AMPHIBIOUS INVASION

THE NORMANDY LANDINGS

The Allied landings on Normandy beaches on D-day, 6 June 1944, comprised the largest amphibious operation ever. With around 160,000 soldiers put ashore in a single day despite heavy resistance, the invasion was a masterpiece of planning and organization on a vast scale.

The outcome of the Normandy landings depended upon experience accumulated by the Allies since the beginning of World War II – on Sicily and the Italian mainland, in the Dieppe Raid of 1942, and by US Marines in the Pacific. The most important lesson learned had been never to underestimate the difficulty of such an enterprise.

Successful landings required command of the air and sea, and the Allies achieved this on D-day. With most of the German Luftwaffe assigned to the Eastern front, or to homeland defence, Allied aerial dominance over the beaches was assured. Meanwhile, Allied navies deployed more than 1,200 warships for the invasion which, in combination with mines and air patrols, deterred attacks by German surface ships and submarines.

A second necessity for the landings was tactical surprise. The enemy knew an invasion was being prepared, but not where or when it would come, and deception operations made them expect an attack on the more obvious Pas-de-Calais. Poor weather in early June delayed this invasion by a day, but also put the defenders off their guard, since they believed landings would not be attempted in such conditions.

The five target beaches were codenamed Utah, Omaha, Gold, Juno, and Sword. Utah and Omaha were assigned to American troops, Gold and Sword to the British, and Juno to the Canadians. The invasion fleet set off from ports across the south of England on the night of 5–6 June, assembling south of the Isle of Wight. Minesweepers led the way across the English Channel, clearing a passage for

other warships and troop transports, while airborne troops landed by parachute and glider to seize objectives behind the beaches. At dawn Allied warships, including six battleships, opened fire on the German Atlantic Wall coastal defences. This was the first warning the German defenders had of the impending invasion.

THE FINAL APPROACH

Allied soldiers transferred into more than 4,000 landing craft for the final approach. The craft were a mixture of flat-bottomed plywood Landing Craft, Vehicle, Personnel (LCVPs), Landing Craft Assaults (LCAs), and others, with ramps in the bow that lowered for the men to exit. Other specialized landing craft transported tanks or provided supporting fire.

Conditions were difficult. Tanks with floats designed to “swim” sank in the rough waters. Seasickness was rife, and on leaving the boats troops had to wade through deep water straight into enemy fire. Some soldiers who exited their crafts too far from shore drowned, dragged under by the weight of their equipment.

Despite losses of around 10,000 casualties, the landings succeeded, giving the Allies a foothold in occupied Europe. Only at Omaha beach were soldiers nearly driven back into the sea; many US tanks and engineers were lost before reaching shore, and defences were strong after inaccurate Allied bombing. Even there, with the help of well-directed naval gunfire, American troops established a secure beachhead by nightfall, and floating Mulberry harbours were towed into position to enable the troops ashore to receive supplies.

